Fallout

By S.W. Senek

Harold and Janet, in their late thirties/early forties, are in the midst of putting on their protective suits - they look more like cheap yellow rain coats/trousers. Harold wears a stopwatch around his neck.

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: In the September (1961) issue of Life magazine, President Kennedy advised, in a letter, that Americans build fallout shelters - causing a wave of "shelter mania " Off and on until the early '60s, Americans built underground rooms that promised to protect them from a nuclear attack.

ACTOR: Playing on traditional imagery of women as domestic caretakers, the government promoted advertisements targeted at housewives for "Grandma's Pantry," a home shelter that women should stock with canned goods, first-aid kits, and flashlights.

ACTRESS: Commercial firms marketed a range of safehouses, that ranged from a "$13.50 foxhole shelter" to a $5,000 "deluxe" model that included a phone, beds, toilets, and even a Geiger counter.

ACTOR: Life *magazine even ran a story on a young newlywed couple who spent their honeymoon in a steel-and-concrete room 12 feet underground. "Fallout can be fun," the article said.*

ACTRESS: The time is October 1961, one year before the Cuban missile crisis. Down in their basement bomb-shelter, a husband & wife find themselves at odds over the definition of "preparedness."

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JANET: I have to get out.

HAROLD: No, we don't have time. Put the suit on. *(He looks at his stopwatch.)* My watch says six minutes, fifteen seconds - that's practically six minutes.

JANET: I know how long six minutes is.

HAROLD: *(Listening to a sound coming from above.)* Wait - did you hear that?

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JANET: What?

HAROLD: Shhh - I thought I heard something - upstairs.

JANET: It's the cat. Pickles. Harold, it's hot - I'm suffocating.

HAROLD: No, you're not. Where's my other boot?

JANET: My zipper's broke -

HAROLD: Did you move my boot?

JANET: I said my zipper is - I can't.

HAROLD: You have to. *(He looks at his stopwatch.)* Janet - hurry. *(He puts single boot on.)* Forget the zipper and boot - checklist - checklist! *(Holds up a clipboard.)* Let's get the blankets ready. Survival, Janet, survival.

JANET: I'm tired.

HAROLD: Do you think the Russians care if you're tired? Fourteen minutes - fourteen minutes - that's how fast these bombs are. *(Looking for the labeled box of blankets.)* Where's the blanket box? Why aren't the labels facing out?

JANET: Harold, how many times? We get up in the middle of the night - down here - stay up all night - reload supplies all day - sleep for a half hour - down here - how long do we have to do these drills? *(Harold opens a box and pulls out a shredded blanket.)* It's insane.

HAROLD: Did you let Pickles down here?

JANET: Me?

HAROLD: I told you not to - that's it - the cat's gone! *(Harold pantomimes strangling.)*

JANET: But you like Pickles -

HAROLD: A goner I tell you! Checklist! *(Looks at what's next on the checklist.)* Flashlights.

JANET: How many more nights of these drills? They're going to fire you –

HAROLD: Let them. This is more important - are you sure you didn't hear anything up stairs?

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JANET: The dealership called, Harold. You can't stop showing up for work. We need the money - and I want sleep - Pickles wants sleep.

HAROLD: No, you want to live.

JANET: No, I want to sleep.

HAROLD: Stop this. We agreed. *(Searching in a box.)* We should have two more flashlights.

JANET: We're going crazy - that's what we're doing - that's what I'm doing.

HAROLD: When that bomb hits, you're going to be thanking me. Now where the hell are the other flashlights? It should be in the box labeled flashlights.

JANET: If a nuclear bomb hits, I'm not thanking anyone.

HAROLD: This is no time for jokes.

JANET: Who's joking? With six minutes left, I'm not joking.

HAROLD: *(Looking at stopwatch.)* Four minutes, forty seconds - Christ you've wasted over a minute. We're running behind schedule. Double check the powdered milk while I look for the flashlights. *(He continues looking through boxes.)*

JANET: Don't you see what this is doing to you?

HAROLD: Time Janet, time. How many powdered milks?

JANET: Twenty-two. That's how many we had last night - how many we had the night before - how many we had when we started. That's how many we bought!

HAROLD: Christ, I don't need your attitude.

JANET: What do you need from me?

HAROLD: Where's the powdered milk? I need you to take this seriously.

JANET: I am - I have been.

HAROLD: Flashlights, Janet! Four minutes, ten seconds! Do you know how behind we are? Do you? *(She sits')* Wait what are you doing? Sitting? You can't sit. No - get up and help me. If you don't, we'll do it again. Is that what you want?

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JANET: No, Harold.

HAROLD: This is serious stuff I mean Kennedy said - *(Grabs news clipping')* it's right here! The Russians could attack us. And you know he doesn't joke. We have to be prepared. Kennedy said -

JANET: *(Mockingly.)* "Kennedy said - Kennedy said."

HAROLD: When this thing hits Janet - and it will - it will level everything. The schools, post office, library, your goddamn hair salon - people - family. But not us, you hear me? And all those neighbors -

JANET: The ones that look at us funny -

HAROLD: They look at us funny because they're not prepared - the hell with them. They don't believe. *(Looks at stopwatch.)* Three and a half minutes! Checklist!

JANET: *(Mockingly.)* Three and a half minutes! Three and a half minutes! Checklist!

HAROLD: Don't mock me.

JANET: *(Mockingly.)* "Don't mock me."

HAROLD: And where's the water? Did you refill the water bottles today? Where's the fresh water?

JANET: I forgot.

HAROLD: You what?! What good is the powdered milk without water?

JANET: I forgot - the bottles are in the garage.

HAROLD: Christ, how could you forget - do you know how important it is to have fresh water? Every day I say refill - and where are the flashlights!

JANET: Every day - I'm sick of filling up one hundred and fifty-two bottles of water! Earthly sick of it! Do you know that yesterday when I was filling them up in the bath tub, I about drowned? I slipped and hit my head. Did you even ask about the bump on my head? No.

HAROLD: Why is *this* box empty?

JANET: Don't you care? I could have been dead filling up these goddamn bottles up for

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a bomb that will never hit us! That's right - I don't think it will hit us. I think it's all a crock of - of -

HAROLD: Don't you even finish that thought.

JANET: I'm right.

HAROLD: *We* did this together - together.

JANET: No, *you* did this. I did it for you. All I heard for six weeks was, "a shelter Janet, that's the only way we'll survive." I agreed because that's the only way I could survive with you - if I heard you mention the shelter one more day -

HAROLD: This is a fine time - *(Looks at the stopwatch again.)* Christ - less than two minutes! Now's not the time for this. Unbelievable! This box has bricks in it -

JANET: Unbelievable? You're unbelievable - do you know how much money we've spent on this junk?

HAROLD: Now it's junk?

JANET: Yes! It's junk.

HAROLD: Well, we'll have tons of money after the goddamn bomb hits - tons! All those idiots that didn't protect themselves - it'll be like a free bank when we get out of here.

JANET: Will you listen to yourself? Everyone will be dead! There'll be nothing to buy!

HAROLD: Another box of bricks - who put these in here? Janet? Where are all the cans of food?

JANET: They're in the kitchen - where they belong.

HAROLD: They belong down here! Christ - *(Looks at his stopwatch.)* minute twenty! Now we'll have nothing to eat. How are we supposed to survive without food and water?! And where's my flashlight!!

JANET: We have each other.

HAROLD: You - YOU! You did this? AHHHH!

JANET: I left Band-Aids.

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HAROLD: What?

JANET: In case we get cut.

HAROLD: Everything up above is going to be destroyed, and you managed to keep the Band-Aids. *(Looks at his stopwatch.)* Fifty seconds - forget the list - we have to get into position.

JANET: I'm not getting into position.

HAROLD: No, you have to - *(He tries to take her, but she breaks free.)*

JANET: And crouch for what - the next two hours.

HAROLD: That's what we're supposed to do.

JANET: Not me.

HAROLD: Why are you doing this? Survival, Janet - survival!

JANET: I'm not getting into that ridiculous position.

HAROLD: You have thirty seconds, Janet - do you hear me! Thirty seconds before it all blows up!

JANET: Bon Voyage!

HAROLD: Well, I'm getting down! You'll be sorry.

JANET: Then do it.

HAROLD: *(He gets down on the floor.)* Don't make me live like this - now get down! Please!

JANET: No.

HAROLD: Fifteen seconds. Janet! You listen to me goddamn it! Twelve, eleven, ten, nine - Janet - seven, six, five, four, three, two, one! *(Beat ofsilence.)* JANET!!!!!! GODDAMN IT - YOU'RE DEAD! ARE YOU HAPPY NOW! YOU RUINED IT! YOU SABATOGED ME - THIS EVERYTHING!

JANET: Good.

HAROLD: Good? GOOD?! CHRIST! What if this was real! YOU'RE GODDAMN DEAD.

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DEAD, DEAD!!

JANET: Don't you get it? I DON'T CARE! *(Beat)* I can't take living in fear anymore! It's everywhere we go - the television - the radio - newspapers - that's all people talk about - that's all you ever talk about. Don't you see what it's done to us? We used to talk about dinner, children, how many cars you sold - we were normal. Now you're possessed and I don't even know you anymore. Every waking moment it's the shelter - get the food for the shelter, paint the shelter, breakfast, lunch and dinner in the shelter, drills in the shelter - reading in the shelter, boxes in the shelter, blankets, water, powdered milk - our whole life in this God forsaken shelter. Right now, I wish the bomb would hit this shelter and take us from our misery. BOOM! BOOOOOOM!!

HAROLD: Janet, they're out there - Communists - they don't believe like we do - they don't have freedom like we do - they hate us. They're waiting to get us. Waiting with their ships in the ocean or God knows where - off the coast - Christ, in our back yard - upstairs even.

JANET: Then so be it - there's nothing we can do.

HAROLD: You're wrong. We have this. Survival, Janet - survival! GOD DAMN SURVIVAL!

JANET: I DON'T WANT TO SURVIVE! *(Pause')* I'm sorry, Harold, but I don't want to be the only ones living. Don't you see, I couldn't bear to walk out of here and not recognize anything because it's been leveled - and say "hey, remember such in such was there - remember so and so - and here's their foot bone." No. I'd be like dying twice - dying alone. I like my memories the way they are - the schools, the children - you standing in the lot trying to sell Cadillacs. I don't want that to change. And I can't keep living like this every single day. This right now - *this* is killing me.

HAROLD: Well, you're wrong. And you know it. Checklist! *(Looks at the checklist.)* Now I have to make a replacement list. First, flashlights. *(Knocks some boxes over in*

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frustration.) Where did you put the flashlights!

JANET: Harold, let's leave this lunacy.

HAROLD: Now it's lunacy? Well, we got a war to fight - and I'm doing my part ... with or without you. Now as soon as I restock everything, I'm running the drill again, and again, and again. Until its right. *(Beat.)* Shhhh - did you hear that?

JANET: Hear what - I didn't hear anything.

HAROLD: That - I heard a noise - again. Upstairs. *(He crouches behind some boxes.)*

JANET: It's Pickles.

HAROLD: Christ. They're here. Them - THEM! Spies.

JANET: Harold! Please.

HAROLD: They're up there.

JANET: There's nobody up there! Harold –

HAROLD: Shhh -

JANET: *(She removes her suit.)* Harold ... I can't take this anymore. *(Beat.)* I'm going to Mom's or June's.

HAROLD: Don't go - please, they're up there. Get behind the boxes - hurry.

JANET: No. *(Pause')* I'm going - and I'm taking Pickles with me.

HAROLD: Janet - don't go up. They'll take you. Please Janet - I'm begging you - begging! *(He grabs her.)* We're safe here. We're survivors. We have to survive.

JANET: HAROLD! LET ME GO!!

HAROLD: *(He lets go.)* Alright - alright - shhhh, shhhh. Goddamn it - fine. *(Dives back into the boxes.)* Don't tell them that I'm down here. Promise me.

JANET: *(Finishes removing her suit)* There's no one up there -

HAROLD: *(He reaches out and grabs her again more sternly.)* Just promise me.

JANET: *(Frustrated.)* Harold - *(Trying to make sense of his state of mind.)* I promise. *(He lets go and stacks the boxes.)* I hope it ends soon. *(Beat.)* Goodbye, Harold.

HAROLD: *(He momentarily stops stacking boxes and looks at Janet. Loud whisper.)* You'll

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be sorry. Whether they get you upstairs - or when the bomb hits - you'll see - you'll be sorry! *(Beat. He continues stacking the boxes. Janet slowly exits. Blackout)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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